HOW KIDS EAT

A Thanksgiving Nature Documentary

Written and directed by Amanda Young for ACS

A play in six specimens

Sixth Grade Thanksgiving Program

Running time, about 12 minutes

Cast of 13 or more

Version 2, updated October 13, 2026

CAST

NARRATOR 1	*clipboard, safari hat, very serious*
NARRATOR 2	*the same, but more dramatic, carries a stopwatch*
SIGN KID	*holds up the title cards, never speaks*
NOODLE KID	*the sensory eater, nothing may touch*
PEA KID	*the kid who eats nothing, will bargain*
THE TALKER	*fork up, it never lands*
MESSY KID	*everything must touch*
SHOVEL KID	*the speed eater, rice and gravy*
SECONDS KID	*the overeater*
MOM	*patient, undefeated*
SLOW KID	*on bite one the entire play*
THE DOG	*a kid in dog ears, under the table*
EXTRAS	*as many as you have, seated at the table*

THE SET

One long table facing the audience, with the chairs behind it so the audience sees every plate. A fake plant off to one side. The Dog lives under the table and pops up when needed.

STAGING NOTES

- Keep everything turned out toward the audience. If the audience cannot see the plate, the joke is gone.
- Use safe stand-in food. Real dry rice, plastic peas, plain cooked noodles. Nobody actually eats on stage.
- Put a tarp or an old sheet under Messy Kid and Shovel Kid.
- Slow Kid should be on stage before the lights come up and should still be there at the blackout.
- The narrators carry the show. Cast two kids who can keep a straight face.

OPENING

THE TABLE

(Narrators enter from opposite sides. Slow Kid is already at the table, fork raised, absolutely motionless.)

NARRATOR 1. *(hushed)* The fourth Thursday of November. A rare and dangerous day.

NARRATOR 2. Today, we observe the North American Sixth Grader as it approaches the most feared event of its year.

BOTH. Thanksgiving dinner.

NARRATOR 1. There are six known kinds of eater. Tonight, we will observe them all.

NARRATOR 2. *(whisper)* Stay very still.

SPECIMEN ONE · THE SENSORY EATER

SPECIMEN ONE

THE SENSORY EATER

(Noodle Kid enters with a plate of fettuccine, sits, and lays out a napkin like a tray of surgical tools.)

NARRATOR 1. The subject has been served fettuccine.

NOODLE KID. Scalpel.

NARRATOR 2. It has not been served fettuccine. It has been served a problem.

NARRATOR 1. The sensory eater. Every bite must pass inspection. Color. Texture. Temperature. Attitude.

(Noodle Kid begins removing things one at a time, holding each one up to the light, then setting it on the napkin.)

NOODLE KID. Green thing. *(sets it down)* Green thing. Green speck. Suspicious green speck. *(squints)* Mushroom. In my HOUSE.

NARRATOR 1. Note the precision. Not one flake of parsley will survive.

(Noodle Kid starts wiping the sauce off the noodles one at a time and lining them up in a row.)

NARRATOR 2. It has now removed the sauce.

NARRATOR 1. The sauce is the food.

NARRATOR 2. Not to this one.

(Noodle Kid holds up a plate with about four bare noodles on it and beams. Then a cranberry rolls slowly across the table and touches the plate. Noodle Kid stares in silent horror.)

NOODLE KID. *(quiet, shaking)* It touched.

NARRATOR 1. Contact.

NOODLE KID. *(standing, to the whole table)* IT TOUCHED.

NARRATOR 2. The plate is now considered contaminated.

(Noodle Kid sits, eats one noodle from the far edge of the plate, and pushes the rest away.)

NOODLE KID. I'm full.

NARRATOR 1. Eleven minutes of work.

NARRATOR 2. One noodle.

(Exits with great dignity, leaving behind a napkin piled with the entire meal.)

SPECIMEN TWO · THE KID WHO EATS NOTHING

SPECIMEN TWO

THE KID WHO EATS NOTHING

(Pea Kid sits with both arms folded, staring at a full plate. Mom stands over the chair.)

NARRATOR 1. Some subjects survive the entire holiday on nothing at all.

NARRATOR 2. Scientists still do not know how.

MOM. Three bites.

PEA KID. One bite.

MOM. Three.

PEA KID. One bite, and I'll be nice to my sister for a week.

MOM. Two bites. I'm getting the gravy. Do not move.

(Mom exits. The second she is gone, Pea Kid springs into action, checking over both shoulders before every move. The narrators call it like a golf tournament.)

NARRATOR 2. *(whisper)* Into the milk.

(Pea Kid drops peas into the glass. Looks pleased. Then notices the milk is now green. Slides the glass toward a neighbor.)

NARRATOR 1. Bold.

NARRATOR 2. Into the mashed potatoes.

(Pea Kid buries a spoonful, pats it smooth like a tiny grave, and makes a small sad face.)

NARRATOR 1. Into the plant.

(Pea Kid stretches way out, dumps peas into the plant, and sits back innocently.)

NARRATOR 2. Into the sock.

NARRATOR 1. *(genuinely concerned)* Into the sock?

(Pea Kid lifts one leg onto the chair and pours peas in. Sits back. Nods.)

NARRATOR 2. And finally, the oldest partnership in nature.

(Pea Kid slowly lowers a hand under the table. The Dog's head pops up, eats, and disappears.)

PEA KID. *(patting the dog)* Good boy. You're the only one who gets me.

(Mom returns with the gravy and looks at the empty plate. Long pause.)

MOM. You ate it?

PEA KID. Every bite.

(Pea Kid stands to leave, and peas pour out of the napkin, the sleeve, the sock, everywhere.)

PEA KID. . . . I'll get those later.

MOM. Sit. *(holds out a spoonful)* You have never even tasted a sweet potato.

PEA KID. And that is how I know I don't like it.

NARRATOR 1. Flawless logic.

PEA KID. I'll lick it. Then technically I tried it.

MOM. One bite. Final offer.

(Pea Kid takes the tiniest possible bite. Chews forever. Grimaces. Then stops. Considers. Takes another. Then eats the whole thing fast.)

PEA KID. *(mouth full, defensive)* This doesn't mean anything.

NARRATOR 2. The subject has eaten. Someone write down the date.

(Mom exits victorious.)

SPECIMEN THREE · THE TALKER

SPECIMEN THREE

THE TALKER

(The Talker sits down in the middle of the table with a full plate, picks up a fork, raises it, and starts talking. The fork does not come down.)

THE TALKER. So this one time at recess, okay, me and Jaden, no wait, it was Mason. No, it was Jaden. We were by the swings,

NARRATOR 1. The talker. Its fork has been raised for some time.

NARRATOR 2. Observe. The fork approaches the mouth.

(The fork gets almost all the way in. The Talker pulls it back out to point with it.)

THE TALKER. and THEN the ball goes over the fence,

NARRATOR 2. And it retreats.

(Around the Talker, everyone eats, finishes, and leaves one at a time. The Talker does not notice.)

THE TALKER. so Jaden says, actually it was Mason, so Mason says,

NARRATOR 1. The food is now cold.

NARRATOR 2. The table is empty.

NARRATOR 1. Even the dog has left.

(The Dog crawls out from under the table and exits, shaking its head. Mom enters and starts clearing, and slides the Talker's full plate out from under the fork.)

THE TALKER. and that is why we can't go by the swings anymore. *(finally lowers the fork, looks down)* Hey. Where's my food?

MOM. Dinner was an hour ago.

THE TALKER. *(outraged)* I didn't even get to eat! *(beat)* Okay, that reminds me of a story.

(Mom exits. The Talker follows, still talking.)

SPECIMEN FOUR · THE MESSY EATER

SPECIMEN FOUR

THE MESSY EATER

(Messy Kid enters, tucks a napkin into the collar like a bib, and rolls up both sleeves. Pulls Noodle Kid's abandoned plate over and begins mashing everything together with a spoon, humming happily.)

NARRATOR 1. In the very same habitat, the exact opposite creature.

NARRATOR 2. The messy eater. Nothing on the plate is safe. Nothing near the plate is safe.

(Messy Kid adds turkey, stuffing, cranberry, gravy, corn. Stirs. Considers. Adds a roll. Stirs. A splash of gravy lands on a neighbor, who slowly wipes it off.)

NARRATOR 2. It's all going the same place.

MESSY KID. *(to the audience, mouth full)* It's all going the same place!

(Messy Kid reaches over and dumps a slice of pie in. Both narrators react.)

NARRATOR 1. No.

NARRATOR 2. He wouldn't.

MESSY KID. *(stirring the pie in)* Trust me.

(Eats a huge bite with both hands. Closes both eyes. Absolutely transcendent. There is gravy on one elbow, cranberry on an ear, and stuffing in the hair.)

MESSY KID. Thanksgiving soup.

NARRATOR 1. The subject has somehow gotten gravy on its back.

NARRATOR 2. We have no explanation.

(Messy Kid stands, takes off the napkin bib, which is perfectly clean, folds it neatly, sets it down, and exits.)

NARRATOR 1. The napkin. Spotless.

SPECIMEN FIVE · THE SPEED EATER

SPECIMEN FIVE

THE SPEED EATER

(Shovel Kid enters at a sprint with a heaping plate of rice and gravy, and sits. Narrator 2 pulls out a stopwatch.)

NARRATOR 1. Rice and gravy.

NARRATOR 2. Brace yourself. *(clicks the stopwatch)*

(Shovel Kid eats like the plate is about to be taken away. No pauses. No breathing. Rice flies everywhere, and one grain lands on the forehead.)

NARRATOR 1. No chewing has been observed.

NARRATOR 2. He is not tasting it. He is storing it.

(Shovel Kid slams the fork down and sits back, totally serene.)

NARRATOR 2. *(clicks the stopwatch)* Four seconds. A new record.

SHOVEL KID. *(polite, a grain of rice on the forehead)* May I please be excused?

NARRATOR 1. Note the excellent manners.

SHOVEL KID. *(eyeing a neighbor's plate)* Are you gonna finish that?

(The neighbor pulls the plate in close and guards it with both arms. Shovel Kid exits at a sprint.)

SPECIMEN SIX · THE OVEREATER

SPECIMEN SIX

THE OVEREATER

(Seconds Kid enters with a plate piled so high it takes both arms and a chin to hold it.)

NARRATOR 1. And now, the largest specimen of all.

NARRATOR 2. Not in size. In appetite.

SECONDS KID. *(sitting)* Just a little plate. I'm not that hungry.

(Seconds Kid eats it all and holds up the empty plate. Mom refills it. Again. Again, faster.)

NARRATOR 1. Seconds.

NARRATOR 2. Thirds.

NARRATOR 1. I have lost count.

NARRATOR 2. Fifths.

(Seconds Kid builds a pyramid of eleven dinner rolls and growls at anyone who reaches for one.)

SECONDS KID. Those are for later.

NARRATOR 1. It is now later.

(Seconds Kid eats the pyramid, leans back, and groans.)

SECONDS KID. I'm so full. I'm never eating again. I mean it this time.

NARRATOR 2. The subject has eaten its own body weight in stuffing.

NARRATOR 1. It cannot possibly fit any more.

MOM. *(offstage)* Who wants pie?

(Seconds Kid is up and out of the chair before Mom finishes the sentence.)

THE FINALE

FINALE

PIE

(Everyone drifts back to the table, groaning, stuffed, draped over the chairs. Slow Kid is still there, still on bite one. Seconds Kid is already seated, fork in hand, napkin tucked in.)

PEA KID. I'm so full.

NOODLE KID. I can't move.

SHOVEL KID. I may never eat again.

THE TALKER. Okay, so this one time,

EVERYONE. SHHH.

NARRATOR 1. The herd has reached capacity. There is no room left.

NARRATOR 2. None whatsoever.

(Mom enters carrying a pie.)

MOM. Who wants dessert?

(Everyone snaps upright at once. Plates out, hands up, total chaos.)

ALL. ME!

NARRATOR 1. Fascinating.

NARRATOR 2. Scientists remain baffled.

(Freeze. The narrators step forward.)

NARRATOR 1. They will not eat their vegetables.

NARRATOR 2. They will not let their food touch.

NARRATOR 1. They will hide peas in a sock.

NARRATOR 2. They will not stop talking.

NARRATOR 1. But they show up. Every single year. To the same table. With the same people.

NARRATOR 2. *(dropping the documentary voice)* And that is kind of the whole point.

BOTH. Happy Thanksgiving.

(Everyone dives for the pie. Blackout. In the dark, one loud crunch from Slow Kid.)

SLOW KID. *(in the dark)* I'm still on my first bite.

E N D

MORE BITS YOU CAN SWAP IN

Every scene in this play stands on its own, so bits can be cut, added, or reordered to fit the class. Here are more, sorted by the kind of kid who should play them.

PHYSICAL ONES, FOR THE FUNNIEST KIDS

The Corn Typewriter. Eats corn on the cob in fast rows, dings at the end of each line, slides back to the start.

The Chipmunk. Stores everything in both cheeks so the plate looks empty, and then an adult asks a question.

The Milk Washer. One bite of turkey, one entire glass of milk. Repeat. Six refills, one piece of turkey.

Volcano Potatoes. Spends the whole meal sculpting a mashed potato volcano with a gravy crater, never eats a bite, and presents it like a science fair project.

TALKY ONES, FOR CONFIDENT READERS

The Food Critic. A sixth grader with a fake accent reviewing Grandma's stuffing. "The texture is bold. Perhaps too bold."

The Kids' Table Escape. One kid keeps sneaking toward the adult table and keeps getting sent back. A good runner through the whole show.

What Is It. "What's this?" "Green bean casserole." "What's in it?" "Green beans." "What ELSE?" "Beans, and a casserole." "I'm going to need a full ingredient list."

TEAM BITS

The Dog Union. Three different kids sneak food to the dog, none of them knowing about the others. The dog staggers out at the end and somebody says the dog looks bigger.

The Bathroom Ferry. A kid asks to go to the bathroom holding a suspiciously full napkin. Asks again. And again. The fourth time, Mom just holds out a hand and the napkin is surrendered.

The Saver. Saves the best bite for last, sets it aside carefully, describes how good it is going to be, turns away for two seconds, and somebody eats it. Big slow motion NOOOO.

RUNNING GAGS TO THREAD THROUGH

Slow Kid, still on bite one, in every single scene. It pays off in the blackout.

The Dog popping up under the table whenever a plate gets desperate.

Sign Kid's title cards, and one card that is clearly wrong so Sign Kid has to flip it around.

The green milk glass from Specimen Two, slid quietly down the table all night, until somebody finally drinks it.